Indian Independence.[30] Malwinder Jit Singh Warraich, who had in earlier years interviewed the surviving members of Bhagat Singh's family, including his mother at her home, had in relation to the blood soaked bottle of sand written, 'The massacre of Jallianwala is a watershed in our struggle for freedom. It is also a turning point in the life of young Bhagat Singh.'[31]

Yet another event of colonial violence that left a deep imprint on Bhagat Singh's mind was the Babbar Akali Agitation of 1926. Bhagat Singh got to learn about this after he had fled from the National College, Lahore, when confronted with the prospect of marriage in 1923, as he had headed for Kanpur. There he joined the editorial board of the weekly *Pratap*, and began publishing. It was there that he also formed close relationships with leading revolutionaries who retained life-long attachments with him: Shiv Verma, Jaidev Kapoor, Batukeshwar Dutt, Bejoy Kumar Sinha, to name but a few. He became fully immersed in life there and also helped with the flood relief operations in Kanpur at the time. He was even appointed headmaster of National School at Shadipur village in Aligarh District, after the owner of *Pratap*, Ganesh Shankar Vidyarthi, sent Bhagat Singh there to keep him away from the prying eyes of the police. However, when six activists[32] of the Babbar Akalis were hanged in Lahore Central Jail on 27 February 1926 for launching an armed revolt against the British Empire, on the festival of Holi, Bhagat Singh wrote an essay titled 'Drops of Blood on the Day of Holi' ('Holi ke din khoon ke chhinte') on 15 March 1926 for *Pratap*. Bhagat Singh was then eighteen years old and was deeply affected.

Once again, however, he learnt from their example which in the fullness of time he would himself emulate. Thus, he refers to how 'the contempt and lightheartedness that these people had demonstrated for nearly two years during their trial proved how earnestly [they] had been waiting for just such a day'. In fact, when 'the Honourable Judge pronounced his verdict after months' one could see how 'the brave defendants thundered' and 'the sky reverberated with their enthusiastic victory cries'.[33] Initially, five had been sentenced to death and the sixth to exile in the Andaman Islands. Such was the unremitting ferocity of colonial violence that on appeal, rather than reduce the sentence of the five, all six were sentenced to the gallows. This is